BAY OF BENGAL INITIATIVE FOR MULTI-SECTORAL TECHNICAL AND ECONOMIC COOPERATION (BIMSTEC)

Another regional initiative which is to emerge as an important economic bloc connecting South Asia and South-east Asia is the BIMSTEC. Earlier it was BIST-EC, an economic cooperation initiative comprising Bangladesh, India, Sri Lanka and Thailand. It came to existence on 6 June 1997 in Bangkok with the adoption of the Bangkok Declaration. Later, with Myanmar joining the grouping in a Special Ministerial Meeting in Bangkok in December 1997,
the name was changed to BIMSTEC. Nepal became an observer country in the Second Ministerial Meeting in Dhaka in 1998, and acquired full membership in 2003. Bhutan also became a full-fledged member in 2003.

The Bangkok Declaration on the Establishment of BIST-EC embodies the aims and objectives of BIMSTEC. They are:

1. to create an enabling environment for rapid economic development and to accelerate social progress in the sub-region,
2. promote active collaboration and mutual assistance on matters of common interest,
3. provide assistance to each other in the form of training and research facilities,
4. cooperate more effectively in joint efforts that are supportive of, and complementary to national development plans of member states,
5. maintain close and beneficial cooperation with existing international and regional organizations, and
6. cooperate in projects that can be dealt with most productively on a sub-regional basis, and which make best use of available synergies.

BIMSTEC was initiated with the goal to combine the ‘Look West’ policy of Thailand, and ASEAN with the ‘Look East’ policy of India and South Asia. Thus BIMSTEC may be seen as a link between ASEAN and SARRC, i.e., South Asia and South-east Asia.

In the first Summit on 31 July 2004, leaders of the group agreed that